

protection until they have the ability to repay? Often that is an individual decision. First and foremost, Christians must be willing to accept the absolute requirement to repay what they owe.

The issue of motive must be addressed. Is the action being taken to protect the legitimate rights of the creditors? I believe that answer can be found in asking whether assets are purposely withheld from the creditors. For example, many times when someone files for corporate or personal bankruptcy protection, assets have been transferred to the spouse or to other family members, as in the case of Bud's partners. If a husband and wife are treated as one, according to God's Word, then their assets must also be treated as one.

In general, the bankruptcy laws are meant to protect the debtor, not the creditor. But if the intent is merely to protect the assets of the debtor, it is unscriptural. It is better to suffer the loss of all assets rather than to lose one's integrity.

Here are some questions individuals and couples have asked about bankruptcy:

What effect will the Chapter 13 bankruptcy have on our future credit?

A credit reporting agency can report that you filed for bankruptcy protection for up to seven years after the date of that action. Chapter 7 bankruptcies can be reported for up to ten years. Therefore, any potential lender that inquires about your credit history will receive that report.

Is there any way to clear our credit rating?

Not really. Too often in our society people act as if there are no consequences of a bankruptcy, but that simply is not true. As already noted, a bankruptcy will appear on your credit report for seven to ten years. Even after this period, you may have some difficulty getting credit.